politics is increasingly local, and there is only one military superpower that can project military power where it wishes, when it wishes, across the globe: namely, the United States. The world is thus multipolar economically, unipolar militarily, and fragmented politically.

The absence of order is evident in both aspects of what an order promises: the maintenance of peace and security and in the formation and application of norms and rules.

What has occurred in West Asia after the horrific terrorist attack by Hamas in October 2023, and Israel's brutal response, which continued through 2024, has shown the limitations of powers other than the US outside their immediate peripheries. This is not a multipolar world, though many governments like to say it is since it flatters them to project themselves as a present or future pole.

The scale of the humanitarian disaster in Palestine has also shown the limited ability of the international state-system and multilateral organisations. It is unreasonable to expect organisations established and run by member-states to be effective when those member-states are quarrelling with each other.

The past decade has shown us that there is presently no world order capable of dealing with transnational threats like climate change, global terrorism, and the developing country debt crisis. There has not been a binding international agreement on an issue of consequence for over a decade. In the absence of a settled or agreed order, nor are we able to regulate new domains like cyberspace or technologies like AI that offer opportunities that seem to be matched only by the risks they could pose.

A consequence of an absent order is great power rivalry, jostling to assert themselves and their interests. The unintended consequence of great power rivalry is the opening up of opportunities for middle and other powers to play the great powers off against one another and to pursue their own agendas, whether it is Russia in the Ukraine, Israel in Palestine and Syria and against Iran, Turkey in Syria, or China in the South China Sea and the Himalayas, Azerbaijan with Armenia, and even the Maldives vis-a-vis India. Instances of opportunism are legion and multiplying.

What does this mean for the world in 2025? Will the re-election of Trump as US president change the dynamic of international relations and geopolitics? Individual leaders like Trump could exacerbate or soften some trends. For instance, China-US rivalry could become more acute if Trump does not manage to strike a deal provoked by his tariff threats and overcome his natural inclination to isolationism; US-Russia relations could improve somewhat; and US allies in Asia, like Japan and South Korea, could be forced to strike further out on their own in looking after their own security. But such shifts are likely to be on the margin rather than affecting the basic trends, because most of the factors mentioned above are structural and intrinsic to the nature of the present international system.

Nor should one expect coherent and coordinated international responses to transnational challenges like climate change or debt or terrorism. Indeed, the lack of an order brings into question the continued steady growth of the world economy.

WITH SEVERAL COUNTRIES IN THE SUBCONTINENT **IN CRISIS, INDIA MUST TIGHTEN ECONOMIC BONDS WITH** THEM AND BE A FACTOR OF POLITICAL AND ECONOMIC SECURITY FOR THEM IN AN UNCERTAIN WORLD

For India, this means that we will be operating in a much more difficult international environment. This is a time to concentrate on building our capabilities at home, and on pacifying our periphery. Several countries in the subcontinent are in crisis. In crisis lies opportunity. Now is when we might tighten economic bonds within the subcontinent and become a factor of political and economic security for them in an uncertain world, and to be a provider of security, without becoming an issue in their domestic political turmoil. There is also economic opportunity for a country of India's size and level of development if we are willing to engage economically with the most dynamic economies of the world in Asia east of India. The hard part will be managing the relationship with China until self-strengthening restores deterrence on the border. Both the US and China are increasingly domestically preoccupied. And great power rivalry, such as that between China and the US, also makes space for India and its like-minded partners to influence international outcomes. This will not be easy, but it can be rewarding for a power like India which hopes to improve the working of the international system, something that a rigid world order would oppose, and that the present world between orders permits. ■

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